THE RUSSO-SWEDISH WAR

KING GUSTAV III OF SWEDEN was an unpopular ruler who hoped to drum up support for his rule by success in war. Seeking to profit from the involvement of Russia's empress Catherine II in a conflict with Ottoman Turkey in the Black Sea, he pre-emptorily demanded that Russia hand over Finland. When the Russians refused, in June 1788 he faked a Russian attack on Sweden and declared a war of self-defense. As usual in the Baltic the conflict that ensued was fought both by coastal fleets, including galleys, and by deep-sea sailing ships. Foreign naval officers, especially British, played a prominent role in the conflict. Gustav hoped to seize St. Petersburg, the Russian capital, in a swift campaign, but a setback for his ships of the line at Hogland dashed hopes of a quick victory. Despite a success at Svensksund in 1798, Sweden mostly had the worse of the war and narrowly escaped total disaster at Vyborg Bay in July 1790. Yet a stunning victory at Second Svensksund unexpectedly restored Swedish fortunes, allowing them to negotiate a peace without gains on either side. King Gustav was assassinated two years later.

THE RUSSO-SWEDISH WAR

HOGLAND



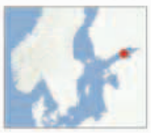
Date July 17, 1788
Forces Russians: 17 ships of the line; Swedish: 15 ships of the line
Losses Russians: 1 ship captured; Swedish: 1 ship captured

Location Off Hogland Island, Gulf of Finland

Early in the war a Swedish sailing fleet commanded by King Gustav III's brother, Prince Karl, entered the Gulf of Finland. The Russians hastily sent out their own ships of the line from Kronstadt, commanded by Scottish-born admiral Samuel Greig. The two fleets met off Hogland Island on a day of light winds that made maneuver painfully slow. The Russians were superior in firepower. Fighting in traditional line of battle, the two sides inflicted considerable losses on one another to little decisive effect. The 70-gun *Prince Gustav*, flagship of Swedish vice admiral Gustav Wachtmeister, was so battered that it surrendered to Greig's 100-gun *Rostislav*. The Russian 74-gun *Vladislav* was surrounded by Swedish ships and taken. After six hours night fell and the battle ended. Russian casualties were heavier—1,800 against the Swedes' 1,200—but the Swedish force withdrew, allowing Russia to claim a strategic victory.

THE RUSSO-SWEDISH WAR

FIRST BATTLE OF SVENSKSUND



Date August 24, 1789
Forces Russians: 86 ships; Swedish: 49 ships
Losses Russians: 2 ships; Swedish: 8 ships

Location Svensksund, Gulf of Finland

Admiral Carl August Ehrensvärd, commanding a Swedish squadron of small sailing ships, gunboats, and galleys, was trapped in Svensksund harbor by two squadrons of Russian coastal vessels. Prince Charles of Nassau-Siegen, in overall command of the Russian forces, attacked from the north with 66 vessels, while a much smaller squadron attacked from the south. Ehrensvärd blocked the northern entrances to the harbor with sunken ships and, posting a few gunboats to cover them, concentrated his forces against the Russian southern squadron. The Russians failed to coordinate their movements, the northern squadron starting far too late, so Ehrensvärd was able to rout the southern squadron before turning to engage Nassau-Siegen. But the Swedes ran low on ammunition and had to retreat under hot pursuit, losing a number of ships in the process. The way was open for the Russian fleet to support land operations in Finland.

THE BREAKOUT FROM VYBORG BAY

Swedish king Gustav III began the third year of his war with Russia boldly, with a bid to land troops on the Russian coast at Vyborg and to establish naval dominance of the Baltic. However, a Swedish attack on part of the Russian fleet in its anchorage at Reval in May misfired, and, in a further action in early June, the Swedes failed to prevent the junction of the main Russian fleet from Kronstadt with the Reval squadron. As a result, the Swedish battle fleet under Grand-Admiral Prince Karl was bottled up in Vyborg Bay with the galley flotilla and troop transports commanded by King Gustav—around 400 ships and 30,000 men under naval siege.

Dangerously short of food and water, and fearing a Russian attack, the Swedish forces needed to break out of the bay. Both feasible channels through the shallow seas were blocked by Russian ships anchored broadside-on with mortar vessels in support. The Swedes decided to break out through the western channel by Krysserort after a feint toward Björkö in the east. It was not until early July that the wind shifted to the east and the attempt could be made.

On the morning of July 3 the ship of the line *Dristigheten*, commanded by Colonel Johan af Puke, led the Swedish battle fleet toward the line of Russian blockade ships, accompanied by the flotilla of coastal galleys inshore to the west. Braving the Russian broadsides, Puke sailed through the blockade between the ships of the line *Selsav* and *St. Peter*, raking them with his cannon as he passed. Overwhelmed by the number of ships bearing down upon them, the Russian blockade vessels were badly shot up as the Swedish ships of the line and oared gunboats came through. The shallowness of the waters was the worst hazard, one ship of the line and four galleys soon running aground. Around 10:00 a.m. the Swedes suffered a spectacular mishap. The rearmost ship of the line, *Enigheten*, was towing a fireship, *Postiljonen*. This was ignited at the wrong moment and collided with *Enigheten*'s stern. The two ships ablaze ran into a third, the frigate *Zamine*, and the whole tangled mass was destroyed in a massive explosion. As smoke blocked visibility, several more Swedish

THE RUSSO-SWEDISH WAR



BREAKOUT FROM VYBORG BAY

Date	July 3, 1790
Location	Near St. Petersburg, Russia
Result	Swedish victory

COMBATANTS

RUSSIA	SWEDEN

COMMANDERS

Vasili Chichagov	**King Gustav III** **Prince Karl, Duke of Sodermanland**

FORCES

Ships: 50 sailing ships 80 galleys	**Ships:** 400, including 21 ships of the line

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** none	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** 6 ships of the line, 3 frigates, 4 galleys



Russian medal
This medal was awarded to the seamen and marines who fought for Russia at Vyborg Bay. Galleys and ships of the line are depicted engaging the Swedes.